crime. The senior cop had spent seven years in jail in the alleged encounter killing of history-sheeter Sohrabuddin Sheikh and two others near Ahmedabad in November 2005 before being discharged after the special CBI court found "no prima facie evidence to link" him to the killings. He also led a team that gunned down the dreaded gangster Anandpal Singh in Churu district in June 2017. That encounter led to widespread protests by members of Singh's Rajput community, forcing the government to order a CBI probe.

Though the police got a clean chit, Anandpal's elimination opened up the space for other small-time gangsters, including Singh's rival Raju Theth, as well as others from adjoining states. As police failed to keep up the pressure, Rajasthan started seeing rising incidents of gang violence and extortion with shopkeepers being shot at in busy markets in broad daylight.

THE TURNING POINT

What made Gehlot sit up and take notice was when Theth, who was trying to get into white-collar crimes with the alleged patronage of some politicians, was killed on his doorstep in Sikar in December 2022 and the Lawrence Bishnoi gang claimed responsibility. Then, on the night of January 28 this year, there was firing outside G-Club, a nightclub in the upscale Tonk Road neighbourhood in capital Jaipur. In all, 19 rounds were fired. The club owner is among the prominent businessmen who had been getting extortion calls to pay 'protection money' since November last year. Bishnoi's hitman Ritik Boxer took credit for this on social media. He was arrested from the Nepal border in March. In all, 13 suspects have been arrested so far, including two minors, one of whom was among the three who had opened fire. The gang had apparently involved the juveniles knowing it would be easier to get them out if they were to get caught.

The gang led by Bishnoi, who has been operating it from jail since his arrest in an encounter in 2014, has become a persistent headache for the state police. Bishnoi made the national headlines after issuing a death threat to actor Salman Khan in 2018 and, more recently, for his gang's involvement in the murder of Punjabi singer Sidhu Moosewala last May. When brought to Jaipur on production warrants in February, Bishnoi is learnt to have told the police that he was not involved in the G-Club firing and similar crimes that took place recently. Due to his "clout", say the police, Bishnoi's name is often used by novices to make extortion calls.

Fearing that local small-time gangsters were progressing into bigger crimes that extended to illegal arms, theft of imported coal and fuel being transported via Rajasthan, interstate liquor and cross-border drug smuggling, and even real estate and exam paper leaks, "we realised that it won't take long," says Director General of Police Umesh Mishra, "for Rajasthan to go the UP way." Top cops began working on strategies to strike at bigger gangs and dissuade smaller ones and history-sheeters from joining them as

